

DIGITAL DECEPTION AND CONSUMER FRAUD IN THE ED-TECH SECTOR: A FORENSIC CASE STUDY OF "LUNAR ASTRO"

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ABSTRACT

This paper presents a comprehensive forensic analysis of "Lunar Astro," an online astrology and educational platform founded by Deepanshu Giri. Utilizing Open Source Intelligence (OSINT) and digital forensic methodologies, this study uncovers a systemic architecture of consumer deception. Key findings include the hijacking of a local restaurant's Google Business Profile to artificially inherit a 5-star rating, the implementation of a "bait-and-switch" proxy consultation model (identified as "Code 5007"), the mathematical fabrication of consumer metrics, and the deployment of black-hat Search Engine Optimization (SEO) tactics, including CSS keyword stuffing and Private Blog Network (PBN) link farming. The evidence indicates severe violations of the Consumer Protection Act, 2019, and the Advertising Standards Council of India (ASCI) guidelines.

1. INTRODUCTION

The rapid digitalization of the Indian educational and astrological sectors has created vulnerabilities for consumer exploitation. "Lunar Astro," operating primarily through the domain *lunarastro.com*, markets premium astrological consultations and courses. The platform claims to serve over 80,000 students and boasts high ratings across various review aggregators. However, preliminary consumer complaints regarding service deficiency prompted a deep-dive forensic investigation into the entity's digital footprint, marketing claims, and operational methodologies.

2. METHODOLOGY

This investigation utilized a multi-disciplinary approach combining Open Source Intelligence (OSINT), source code analysis, and mathematical auditing of published metrics. Data was extracted from Google Maps, Trustpilot, Trustindex, and the entity's

proprietary web properties. Source code inspection was conducted to identify hidden DOM elements and CSS manipulations. Furthermore, external link analysis was performed to uncover associated Private Blog Networks (PBNs).

3. FINDINGS AND FORENSIC EVIDENCE

3.1 Digital Identity Hijacking (Google Maps Exploit)

A chronological audit of Lunar Astro's Google Business Profile revealed a critical anomaly. The entity possesses a 5-star rating; however, sorting the reviews by "Oldest" exposes that the profile originally belonged to a food establishment named "Ranjit Da." Reviews dating back six years explicitly praise "delicious chicken curry" and "good food." By taking over an abandoned or sold listing and altering the business name and category, Lunar Astro successfully inherited a fabricated reputation, deceiving consumers who rely on aggregate ratings.

3.2 The "Code 5007" Proxy Consultation Model

Lunar Astro's marketing heavily leverages the personal brand and purported expertise of its founder, Deepanshu Giri. Consumers pay premium fees under the assumption of receiving expert analysis. The investigation found that post-payment, consultations are systematically outsourced to anonymous, unverified individuals operating under numerical identifiers (e.g., "Code 5007"). This anonymity shields the proxy consultants from accountability and constitutes a classic "bait-and-switch" deceptive practice.

3.3 Mathematical Fabrication of Consumer Metrics

The entity's primary landing page prominently displays the claim: "Trusted by 80,000+ happy Students." A mathematical audit of their own published engagement metrics across all platforms yields the following data:

- Google Reviews: ~3,045
- Trustindex Reviews: ~4,164
- TrustPilot Reviews: ~185

The total verifiable engagement is approximately 7,394. Even assuming a 100% unique conversion-to-review rate, there is a mathematical discrepancy of over 72,000 unaccounted consumers. This demonstrates a deliberate fabrication of metrics to induce a false "bandwagon effect."

3.4 Black-Hat SEO, Keyword Stuffing, and Link Farming

Source code analysis of *lunarastro.com* revealed the use of hidden CSS properties (`display: none;`) to stuff keywords invisibly. The phrase "lunar astro reviews" is repeated 69 times, and "courses" 93 times, designed solely to manipulate search engine crawlers.

Furthermore, a recent OSINT discovery uncovered a dedicated "Link Farm" hosted on Google Sites (<https://sites.google.com/view/reviewsoflunarastro/home>). This page is a textbook Private Blog Network (PBN) exploit.

EVIDENCE EXTRACTION: PBN Link Farm

URL: sites.google.com/view/reviewsoflunarastro/home

- The exact phrase "Lunar Astro Reviews" is repeated 21 times in the text to manipulate Google's algorithm.
- The page contains a massive directory of outbound links pointing to Lunar Astro's Thinkific, Amazon, Trustpilot, and Quora pages to artificially inflate domain authority.
- **The Contradiction:** On this very SEO page, the entity admits to having only ~7,394 total reviews across platforms, directly contradicting their own "80,000+ students" marketing claim.

4. REGULATORY AND LEGAL IMPLICATIONS

The practices documented in this study represent systemic violations of established consumer protection frameworks:

- **Consumer Protection Act, 2019 (Section 2(47)):** The "Code 5007" proxy model and the hijacking of the restaurant's Google Maps listing constitute Unfair Trade Practices and severe deficiency in service.
- **ASCI Guidelines (Chapter 1):** The mathematically impossible claim of 80,000+ students violates the mandate for truthful and honest representation in advertising.
- **Google Search Quality Guidelines:** The use of hidden CSS keyword stuffing and Google Sites link farming are direct violations of Google's spam policies, warranting manual de-indexing.

5. CONCLUSION

The empirical evidence confirms that Lunar Astro is not merely engaging in aggressive marketing, but is operating a highly sophisticated digital fraud architecture. By manipulating digital real estate, fabricating consumer metrics, and utilizing anonymous proxies for service delivery, the entity systematically deceives the public. Immediate regulatory intervention by the CCPA, ASCI, and relevant cyber authorities is required to dismantle this deceptive infrastructure and protect future consumers.

REFERENCES & EXHIBITS

- [1] Google Business Profile Audit: "Lunar Astro Vedic Academy" (Formerly "Ranjit Da"). Extracted October 2023.
- [2] Lunar Astro Official Website Source Code Analysis. Extracted October 2023. (CSS ``display:none`` exploit).
- [3] Private Blog Network (PBN) Link Farm Discovery: <https://sites.google.com/view/reviewsoflunarastro/home>. Extracted October 2023.
- [4] Consumer Protection Act, 2019. Ministry of Law and Justice, Government of India.
- [5] The Advertising Standards Council of India (ASCI) Code for Self-Regulation in Advertising.